

What else to watch: *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* (1920, pp.24–27) ■ *The Bride of Frankenstein* (1935, p.52) ■ *Modern Times* (1936) ■ *Blade Runner* (1982, pp.250–55) ■ *Brazil* (1985, p.340) ■ *The Matrix* (1999) ■ *Minority Report* (2002)



Alfred Abel Actor

Born in Leipzig in 1879, Alfred Abel tried his hand at forestry, gardening, art, and business before taking up acting. Moving to Berlin, he worked with stage director Max Reinhardt, who gave him his first movie role in 1913. He went on to star in more than 100 silent movies, most famously *Metropolis*. Always

elegant, and eschewing florid gestures, Abel remained in demand in the age of sound, but a brief foray into directing was not a success. He died in 1937, two years after the Nazi regime barred his daughter from acting.

Key movies

1922 *Dr. Mabuse the Gambler*
1927 *Metropolis*

In *Metropolis*, the architecture of the city reflects the rigid structure of its society, whose ruling class, led by Fredersen (Alfred Abel), lives in luxurious towers, while the workers, represented by Maria (Brigitte Helm), are consigned to the sunless slums at ground level and below. The two groups—literally the high-ups and the low-downs—know little of each other, and in the smooth running of the machine city their paths never cross. Only when Fredersen's privileged son glimpses the worker Maria and falls in love

with her does the machine begin to break down, as the two groups—the “mind” and the “hands”—are brought together by the heart.

Technology and terror

Lang's movie revels in cutting-edge special effects, but it doesn't trust technology with the future of humanity. The 21st-century city is

depicted as a malevolent monster, a living, breathing machine incapable of compassion. Maria is duplicated as a *Maschinenmensch* (“machine-human”), whose unholy birth would later be imitated by Hollywood in *Frankenstein* (1931). Mechanization is ultimately a means to deceive, dehumanize, and enslave.

Metropolis is often described as the first screen dystopia, and in its prediction of a segregated German society, it is bleakly prescient. But Lang's movie remains optimistic at its core—it believes the human heart can triumph even when our dreams turn into oppressive nightmares, and for all its concerns, it sees a frightening beauty in the world of tomorrow. ■

In an Art Deco vision of hell, the Industrial Machine powering the city is seen as a sacrificial temple of Moloch that consumes its workers.

“

Should I say now that I like *Metropolis* because something I have seen in my imagination comes true, when I detested it after it was finished?

Fritz Lang

”

